from Kabul back to their hills to open the doors of sedition, raise rebellion, loot the caravans, and block the roads.'[56]

Maulana Kashmiri in his *Akbarnama* presents the departure of the khans from Kabul less as an angry protest and more as a considered strategy. According to him, the Afghan sardars, fearful that their loss of salaries would be followed by forced exile to India or even London, decided to take action. They met and swore on the Qu'ran to rise up in rebellion so as to lure the bulk of the British troops out of Kabul, then fall on the British leaders when there were few soldiers left in Kabul to defend them:

> When night fell, all the Khans of Kabul came together
> At the house of Abdullah Khan Achakzai to sit and confer
>
> Now the remedy is in our hands, said they
> The bow is ready and the arrow is in our hands
>
> The waters of this storm have not reached our head
> We must get ourselves ready for action
>
> Dying by the sword on the battlefield
> Is better than living in the prisons of Firang
>
> Like the very devil, all evil is the work of Burnes
> Concealed, he goes about whispering to every soul
>
> So this very night Mohammad Shah Khan Ghilzai must go forth
> With his tribesmen, brave and fierce
>
> They will ignite the fire of battle
> And throw brimstone upon the flames
>
> They will sit hidden between the mountain valleys
> And seize all the traders and travellers upon the road
>
> So the Shah may send his army forth to make war
> Then, when the army leaves, we will deal with Burnes . . .[57]

As fate would have it, the beginning of the Ghilzai rebellion coincided with General Elphinstone going down with a new attack of gout.

A month earlier, Elphinstone's surgeon, Dr Campbell, had inspected his patient and been horrified by what he discovered. According to his confidential report, 'Genl. Elphinstone has been very seriously ill ever since his arrival here. His malady attacked him in all his limbs, making a perfect